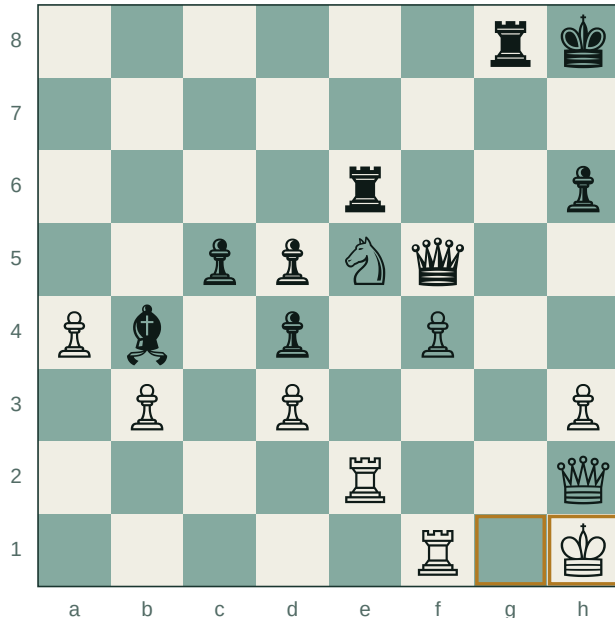


Capture the defender: Black, move 38

Capture the defender

Black to move



Previous move: 38.Kh1. Gold borders mark its start and finish.

WORKED CONTINUATION - COVER THIS SECTION FIRST

38...Rxe5 39. Rxe5 Qxd3

38...Rxe5 The rook captures the knight on e5. Recorded reply: **39.Rxe5**.

39...Qxd3 The queen captures the pawn on d3.

At the end, nominal material is White 23 / Black 21 (P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9). Over this line, Black's balance changes by -1. Activity and king safety still affect the evaluation.

CHECKPOINT

Using P=1, N/B=3, R=5, Q=9, how much does Black's material balance change over the complete line? **Answer:** -1: the balance goes from -1 to -2. Count promotions and every recapture, not just the first gain.

CARRY THE IDEA INTO YOUR GAMES

Do not assume a defender is unique. Another piece may take over its job, or the opponent may decline to recapture.

WHAT THIS POSITION TEACHES

Removing a key defender can transform a protected square into a winning entry. The defender's function explains why the first capture matters.

HOW TO LOOK

Identify the protected target, capture its essential defender, and calculate the follow-up after each plausible recapture.

The defending king is on h1. Geometrically undefended: rook on f1. Check for tactical protection.